MIXED MEDIA MAVEN

Bharti Kher, *54*
Artist



Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH

HOLDING THE SELF IN READINESS

"Practise staying calm and open to all eventualities; small incremental steps are more important than high energy leaps. Preserve some parts just for yourself"

FETISH Jewellery and gold. Her secret guilty pleasure is to look for antique websites and stones "that I never buy"

"GLASS CEILINGS...I'M A CLOUDWALKER. Women like me aren't concerned with ceilings and floors." If Bharti Kher's record-breaking sale at Sotheby's for $1.5 million (Rs 1.24 crore) in 2010 is any indication, shattering glass ceilings—as this sale did for Indian female artists—is something she has done repeatedly. The straight-shooting artist is as much about negotiating ground realities as her work is about quotidian realities shot through with magical realism. Bharti says that commercial success is important to her in that it provides her studio team gainful employment. Most importantly, it gives her the freedom to make what she wants. "Being financially independent for women is everything. My mother taught me that when I was very young, so having my own studio is paramount. Sales, big and small, contribute to that dream," she says.

Married to artist Subodh Gupta, Bharti's art gives form to daily rituals in a manner that reclaims and alters their perspective. Her approach is exploratory, as she reassesses the viewer's relationship with the object. The notion of the self lies at its centre, and is informed by interlocking relationships with human and animal bodies, places and ready-made objects.

While Bharti works in diverse media—paintings, sculptures, installations—her one enduring preoccupation has been the 'bindi', a fascination fostered since 1995. "Bindis met me in a market in Mayur Vihar, Delhi. I was able to make many links around the body, geographies and language. The bindi is a metaphor for the circle of life," Kher says. Her recent exhibition, *The Body is a Place* (2022-23), also features her bindi drawings, the drawing-based installation 'Links in a Chain' and sculptures made from myriad objects.

ACCOMPLISHMENT

One of the most prominent of Indian women artists, she balances the commercial aspects of her art with an unflinching artistic credo

Born and brought up in the UK, cross-cultural references impinge on Bharti's work without limiting it. "Geographies are not fixed and gender is fluid. Both are constructs that we look at differently throughout history," she points out. "To change is inherent in everything: from our bodies to climate, from states of being to politics. Art is a reflective medium...always in flow, never one thing. That's why even if you want to catch it, you can't." Her advice for new artists reflects this: "Get off your phones and look at the real world. Spend time making your language; you don't know what and who you are yet...." Bharti's vision of the transience of life and cultures is widely appreciated. She won the Sanskriti Award in 2003, the YFLO Woman Achiever of the Year award in 2007 and the ARKEN Art Prize in 2010. The Knight of the Order of Arts and Letters came in 2015. ■

–Chumki Bharadwaj